

described it as the “sack” of Lawrence, regarding the event as further proof of Southern intent to create a society dominated by powerful enslavers.

In January 1857, the U.S. Supreme Court reached the notorious Dred Scott decision. The court’s ruling said that prohibiting slavery in a federal territory was unconstitutional, and that Black Americans, free or slave, were not citizens of the United States. This emboldened pro-slavery leaders in Kansas, who met in Lecompton and proposed a new state constitution.